

Materia Medica III – Yang-Tonifying Herbs

Overview

Yang-tonifying herbs warm and supplement **Kidney yang**, assist the **Spleen and Heart yang**, replenish **essence (Jing)**, strengthen sinews and bones, and support fertility, growth, and recovery from chronic deficiency. Many also **dispel cold-damp** from the channels.

General Characteristics (High-Yield)

Attribute	Description
Taste	Sweet (often acrid/salty as secondary)
Temperature	Warm to hot
Channels	Kidney (primary), Liver, Spleen, Heart
Core Actions	Tonify Kidney yang; warm interior; strengthen bones

Global Cautions

- Yang tonics may **aggravate heat** or **yin deficiency with heat**.
- Strong yang tonics are **contraindicated in exterior or excess heat**.
- Several herbs are **hot or toxic** → duration and dosing are exam-relevant.

Herb	Nature / Flavor	Channels	Core Exam Actions	Hallmark Use
Lu Rong	Warm, sweet, salty	Kidney, Liver	Strongly tonifies Kidney Yang & Jing; nourishes Blood	Severe Yang/Jing collapse
Dong Chong Xia Cao	Warm, sweet	Lung, Kidney	Tonifies Kidney Yang; tonifies Lung	Lung–Kidney dual deficiency
Ge Jie	Neutral, salty	Lung, Kidney	Tonifies Lung & Kidney; grasps Qi	Chronic wheezing
He Tao Ren	Warm, sweet	Kidney, Lung, LI	Tonifies Kidney & Lung; moistens intestines	Cough + constipation
Ba Ji Tian	Warm, acrid, sweet	Kidney	Tonifies Kidney Yang; dispels cold-damp	Yang deficiency + Bi
Rou Cong Rong	Warm, sweet, salty	Kidney, LI	Tonifies Yang & Jing; moistens intestines	Yang deficiency constipation
Xian Mao	Hot, acrid, toxic	Kidney	Strongly tonifies Yang; dispels cold-damp	Extreme cold deficiency

Herb	Nature / Flavor	Channels	Core Exam Actions	Hallmark Use
Yin Yang Huo	Warm, acrid, sweet	Kidney, Liver	Tonifies Yang; dispels wind-damp	Libido + Bi
Xu Duan	Slightly warm, bitter, sweet	Kidney, Liver	Tonifies LK; stops bleeding; calms fetus	Pregnancy support
Du Zhong	Warm, sweet	Kidney, Liver	Tonifies LK; strengthens sinews; calms fetus	Low back pain
Gou Ji	Warm, bitter, sweet	Kidney, Liver	Tonifies LK; expels wind-damp; stabilizes Kidney	Leakage + Bi
Gu Sui Bu	Warm, bitter	Kidney, Liver	Tonifies Kidney; heals bones	Fractures
Bu Gu Zhi	Hot, acrid, bitter	Kidney, Spleen	Tonifies Yang; stabilizes Essence; stops diarrhea	Dawn diarrhea
Yi Zhi Ren	Warm, acrid	Kidney, Spleen	Warms KD/SP; retains Essence	Urinary frequency
She Chuang Zi	Warm, acrid	Kidney	Warms Yang; dries damp; kills parasites	Genital itching
Sha Yuan Ji Li	Warm, sweet	Kidney, Liver	Tonifies Kidney; consolidates Jing	Leakage, weak vision
Tu Si Zi	Warm, acrid, sweet	Kidney, Liver	Tonifies Yang & Yin; stabilizes Jing	Infertility
Suo Yang	Warm, sweet	Kidney, LI	Tonifies Yang; moistens intestines	Yang deficiency constipation

Lù róng 鹿茸

Cornu Cervi Pantotrichum | Deer antler velvet

Nature & Flavor: Sweet, salty, warm

Channels: Kidney, Liver

Primary Actions:

1. **Strongly tonifies Kidney Yang and replenishes Jing**
2. **Nourishes Blood; strengthens sinews and bones**
3. **Regulates Chong & Ren; stabilizes Dai Mai**
4. **Heals chronic Yin sores and boils**

Key Indications:

- Severe Kidney Yang deficiency: impotence, infertility, cold extremities

- Developmental delay, weak bones, delayed fontanel closure
- Chong/Ren deficiency cold leading to heavy uterine bleeding or infertility (cold womb), or vaginal discharge
- Chronic ulceration and yin-type boils (concave, oozing clear fluid that does not heal)

Dosage:

- **1–3 g**, powder, decocted separately
- Start at low dose and slowly increase
- Can be made into soup with lean meat

Cautions / Contraindications:

- Yin deficiency with heat
- Internal or exterior heat or phlegm
- Overdose causes Yang rising, internal wind, red eyes, dizziness, epistaxis, or damage of the Yin and Blood.

Special Notes:

Strongest Yang tonic; short-term, severe deficiency only

Dōng chóng xià cǎo 冬虫夏草

Cordyceps sinensis | Cordyceps

Nature & Flavor: Sweet, warm

Channels: Lung, Kidney

Primary Actions:

1. **Tonifies Kidney Yang and Jing**
2. **Tonifies Lung Yin; stops cough and wheezing, transforms phlegm and stops bleeding**

Key Indications:

- Kidney Yang deficiency with chronic fatigue, bone and joint disorders, impotence, tinnitus
- Chronic weak cough/wheezing from Lung–Kidney deficiency, consumptive coughs with blood-streaked sputum.
- Post-illness weakness with spontaneous sweating

Dosage:

- **5–10 g** (decoction or soup)

Cautions:

- Use cautiously in exterior conditions

Special Notes:

Unique: tonifies Yang while supporting Yin (*Cordyceps uniquely tonifies yang + yin*)

Rare Yang tonic that does NOT damage Yin. Best for Lung–Kidney deficiency.

Gě jiè 蛤蚧

Gecko | gecko

Nature & Flavor: salty, neutral

Channels: Lung, Kidney

Primary Actions:

1. **Tonifies Lung and Kidney; relieves wheezing**
2. **Assists Kidney Yang; augments Jing and Blood**

Key Indications:

- Chronic wheezing from failure of Kidneys to grasp Qi
- Consumptive cough, or cough with blood-streaked sputum
- Impotence due to Kidney Yang deficiency
- Daybreak diarrhea, urinary frequency

Dosage:

- **3–7 g** decoction; **1–2 g** powder

Cautions:

- Contraindicated in exterior or excess heat cough

Special Notes:

Stronger respiratory focus than Cordyceps

Think “**grasping Qi**.” Choose when wheezing is the main complaint.

Hé táo rén 胡桃仁

Semen Juglandis regia | Walnut nut

Nature & Flavor: sweet, warm

Channels: Kidney, Lung, Large Intestine

Primary Actions:

1. **Tonifies Kidney and warms the Lung**
2. **Replenishes essence, helps Kidney grasp the qi**
3. **Moistens Intestines**

Key Indications:

- Kidney deficiency with low back and knee weakness, soreness, arthritis
- Chronic cough from Lung–Kidney deficiency, wheezing worse with exertion
- Constipation from dryness (elderly) or due to injured fluids

Dosage:

- **10–30 g**

Cautions:

- Yin-deficient fire
- Loose stools, phlegm-heat cough

Special Notes:

Yang tonic that **also treats constipation and cough**.

Bā jǐ tiān 巴戟天

Radix Morindae Officinalis | Morinda root

Nature & Flavor: Acrid, sweet, slightly warm

Channels: Kidney

Primary Actions:

1. **Assists Kidney Yang**
2. **Dispels wind-cold-damp**

Key Indications:

- Impotence, infertility, cold womb
- Wind-cold-damp Bi with deficiency

Dosage:

- **10–15 g**

Cautions:

- Yin deficiency with heat

Special Notes:

Yang tonic **with Bi pain**—dispels cold-damp better than most.

Ròu cōng róng 肉苁蓉

Herba Cistanches | Cistanche

Nature & Flavor: Sweet, warm

Channels: Kidney, Liver

Primary Actions:

1. **Tonifies Kidney Yang, Jing, and Blood**
2. **Moistens Intestines**

Key Indications:

- Impotence, infertility, spermatorrhea, cold pain or weakness in the lower back and knees (joints)

- Forgetfulness, loss of hearing, tinnitus, dizziness, clear vaginal discharge, amenorrhea, scanty menstrual flow
- Constipation from Yang deficiency with dryness, chronic due to fluid deficiency and dryness

Dosage:

- **10–20 g** (higher doses often required)
- Smaller doses do not show immediate effect
- Salt frying > for treating impotence, low back pain and infertility, directs herb to Kidney

Cautions:

- Diarrhea due to excess heat
- Constipation from excess heat

Special Notes:

Yang tonic that treats constipation - Jing + moisture together.

Xiān máo 仙茅

Rhizoma Curculiginis | Curculigo

Nature & Flavor: Acrid, hot, toxic

Channels: Kidney

Primary Actions:

1. **Strongly tonifies Kidney Yang**
2. **Dispels and eliminates cold-damp**

Key Indications:

- Severe impotence, cold womb (infertility), cold essence (in men), urinary incontinence, nocturnal emission, chest/abdominal pain due to cold.
- Cold-damp Bi with deep deficiency, generalized Bi pain, constitutional Kidney deficiency complicated by invasion of cold-damp obstructing the channels
- Feelings of weakness in bones and sinews, lower back or knee pain

Dosage:

- **3–10 g**- also used as a tincture, pills or powder

Cautions:

- **Hot, toxic**
- Contraindicated in Yin deficiency or heat
- **Not for long-term use**

Special Notes:

Hot and toxic. Use only for extreme Yang deficiency; never long-term.

Yín yáng huò 淫羊藿

Herba Epimedii | Epimedium

Nature & Flavor: Acrid, sweet, warm

Channels: Kidney, Liver

Primary Actions:

1. **Tonifies Kidney Yang**
2. **Dispels wind-cold-damp; treats Bi**

Key Indications:

- Impotence, infertility, spermatorrhea, frequent urination, painful, cold or weak lower back and knees
- Cold-damp Bi with generalized pain, sens of weakness in the bones and sinews
- Chronic numbness and pain in the extremities-use liquor infusion method, drink a small amount daily

Dosage:

- **10–15 g** in decoction, tincture or pills
- Unprocessed > dispels wind and dampness for Bi syndrome
- Frying > tonifying effect on Kidney yang to treat impotence

Cautions:

- Yin-deficient fire

Special Notes:

Libido + Bi. Strong sexual Yang herb with wind-damp action.

Xù duàn 续断

Radix Dipsaci | Dipsacus root

Nature & Flavor: Bitter, acrid, slightly warm

Channels: Kidney, Liver

Primary Actions:

1. **Tonifies Liver & Kidney; strengthens bones and sinews**
2. **Stops uterine bleeding; calms fetus**
3. **Invigorates Blood (trauma), alleviates pain**

Key Indications:

- Low back pain, weak knees and legs, stiffness in the joints

- Threatened miscarriage, restless fetus, bleeding during pregnancy, also used for deficiency related uterine bleeding and vaginal discharge
- Trauma, external sores, pain and swelling in the lower back and limbs from trauma

Dosage:

- **10–20 g** (up to 30 g in severe cases)
- Dry-fried > stronger to stop uterine bleeding

Special Notes:

Dry-fried → stronger hemostatic effect

Pregnancy-safe Yang tonic. Think “repair & stabilize.”

Dù zhòng 杜仲

Cortex Eucommiae | Eucommia bark

Nature & Flavor: Sweet, slightly acrid, warm

Channels: Kidney, Liver

Primary Actions:

1. **Tonifies Liver & Kidney; strengthens sinews & bones**
2. **Calms fetus**
3. **Low back pain in the first trimester of pregnancy with feeling of abdominal prolapse**
4. **Lowers blood pressure**

Key Indications:

- Low back pain, cold legs, intolerance to cold
- Fractured or broken bones
- Pregnancy bleeding from deficiency, unstable pregnancy with restless fetus

Dosage:

- **10–15 g**
- Salt-fried → guides to Kidney
- Dry fried > more effective in tonifying the Liver and Kidney (more potent than unprocessed)
- Grain-based liquor infusion-tincture with other herbs for low back pain

Special Notes:

Low back pain + pregnancy. **Salt-fried = Kidney-directed.**

Gōu jǐ 狗脊

Rhizoma Cibotii Barometz | Chain fern rhizome, cibotam cibotum

Nature & Flavor: bitter, sweet, warm

Channels: Kidney, Liver

Primary Actions:

1. **Tonifies Liver & Kidney, strengthens the sinews and bones**
2. **Expels wind-damp**
3. **Stabilizes Kidney**

Key Indications:

- Stiffness, soreness, or weakness in the lower back, spine, and lower extremities associated with Liver and Kidney deficiency
- Wind-damp Bi pain with soreness or numbness associated with Liver and Kidney deficiency
- Urinary leakage, incontinence, or vaginal discharge due to Kidney Yang deficiency

Dosage:

- **10–15 g**

Cautions:

- Kidney deficiency with heat and urinary difficulty related to damp-heat in the lower jiao

Special Notes:

Yang tonic that **stops leakage** and treats wind-damp.

Gǔ suì bǔ 骨碎补

Rhizoma Drynariae | Drynaria rhizome

Nature & Flavor: bitter, warm

Channels: Kidney, Liver

Primary Actions:

1. **Tonifies Kidney; strengthens bones**
2. **Invigorates Blood; stops bleeding, heals fractures and mends sinews**

Key Indications:

- Bone fractures, low back and knee pain
- Loose teeth, bleeding gums, tinnitus, diarrhea, diminished hearing associated with kidney deficiency
- Traumatic injuries such as falls, fractures, contusions, and sprains

Dosage:

- **10–15 g** in decoction
- Can be soaked in liquor to make tincture for internal use

- Use powder form for topical applications

Cautions:

- Yin or blood deficiency with heat or conditions that do not have blood stagnation.

Special Notes:

Bone-healing herb. Always think fractures.

Bǔ gǔ zhī 补骨脂

Fructus Psoraleae Corylifoliae | Psoralea fruit

Nature & Flavor: acrid, bitter, **very warm**

Channels: Kidney, Spleen

Primary Actions:

1. **Tonifies Kidney Yang, fortifies the yang**
2. **Stabilizes Essence, retains urine**
3. **Tonifies and warms Spleen–Kidney yang; stops diarrhea**

Key Indications:

- Impotence, enuresis, nocturnal polyuria, chronic urinary incontinence
- Dawn diarrhea, borborygmus, and abdominal cold due to cold from deficiency of Spleen
- Feelings of heaviness, coldness and extreme pain in the low back

Dosage:

- **5–10 g**
- For nocturnal polyuria in elderly can be used alone in rice porridge (congee)
- For low back pain take in warm liquor
- Fry with salt to reduce the drying effects and direct to Kidney

Cautions:

- Drying; long-term use depletes Yin
- Contraindicated with Yin-deficiency heat and constipation

Special Notes:

Dawn diarrhea + Yang deficiency. **Drying—watch Yin.**

Yì zhì rén 益智仁

Fructus Alpiniae Oxyphyllae | alpinia fruit, sharp-leaf galangal fruit

Nature & Flavor: acrid, **warm**, astringent

Channels: Kidney, Spleen

Primary Actions:

1. **Warms Spleen & Kidney-dispels cold**
2. **Retains Essence and holds urine**

Key Indications:

- Spleen, Stomach cold from deficiency patterns, cold abdominal pain, excessive salivation, vomiting, lack of appetite
- Diarrhea from cold deficiency
- Urinary frequency (especially at night), incontinence or dribbling of urine, spermatorrhea, uterine bleeding

Dosage:

- **3–6 g** in a decoction but can also be used in pill or powder form.

Cautions:

- Yin-deficient heat or excess heat

Special Notes:

Warm SP/KD and **retain Essence**—urine, saliva, stools.

Shé chuāng zǐ 蛇床子

Fructus Cnidii Monnieri | Cnidium seeds

Nature & Flavor: acrid, bitter, warm

Channels: Kidney

Primary Actions:

1. **Warms & fortifies Kidney Yang**
2. **Disperses cold, dispels wind**
3. **Dries damp; kills parasites; stops itching**

Key Indications:

- Cold womb infertility, vaginal discharge due to damp-cold
- Genital itching, eczema (topical ointment for any kind of weeping, itchy, skin lesion)
- Lower back pain caused by wind-damp-cold + Kidney Yang deficiency

Dosage:

- Internal **3–10 g**
- Topical wash **15–30 g**

Cautions:

- Lower jiao damp-heat; Yin deficiency with heat

Special Notes:

Yang tonic with **topical antipruritic** action.

Shā yuán zi (jì lí) 沙苑蒺藜

Semen Astragali Complanati | astragalus seed, flat-stem milkvetch seed

Nature & Flavor: sweet, warm

Channels: Kidney, Liver

Primary Actions:

1. **Tonifies Kidney; consolidates Jing (Essence)**
2. **Nourishes the Liver, Benefits eyes**

Key Indications:

- General Kidney deficiencies patterns with leakage: spermatorrhea, urinary leakage, polyuria
- Blurred vision, reduced visual acuity and dizziness

Dosage:

- **10–20 g** in decoction, but can also be used in pill or powder form.

Special Notes:

Gentle Jing-stabilizer with **eye benefit**.

Suǒ yáng 锁阳

Herba Cynomorii Songarici | Fleshy stem of cynomorium

Nature & Flavor: sweet, warm

Channels: Liver, Kidney, Large Intestine

Primary Actions:

1. **Tonifies Kidney and fortifies the Yang**
2. **Nourishes Blood, augments the essence, strengthens sinews**
3. **Moistens Intestines, unblocks bowels**

Key Indications:

- Impotence, nocturnal emissions
- Soreness and weakness of the low back and knees
- Constipation from qi, blood or body fluid deficiency leading to dry intestines

Dosage:

- **10–15 g**

Cautions:

- Diarrhea due to Spleen deficiency
- Constipation from excess heat or Yin deficiency heat

Special Notes:

Similar to Rou Cong Rong but **less Blood/Jing, more Yang focus**.

Tù Sī Zǐ 菟丝子

Semen Cuscutae Chinensis | Cuscuta seed; Dodder seed

Nature & Flavor: Pungent, sweet, **neutral** (*taught as slightly warm in some lineages; neutral-to-slightly warm*)

Channels: Kidney, Liver

Primary Actions

1. **Tonifies Kidney Yang and Yin, stabilizes the Essence, reserves urine**
2. **Tonifies Liver and Kidney and benefits the eyes**
3. **Tonifies Spleen and Kidney to stop diarrhea (tonifies Spleen by supporting the Kidney)**
4. **Calms the fetus** (*when deficiency leads to threatened miscarriage*)

Key Indications

- Kidney deficiency with impotence, infertility, low libido, tinnitus, sore/painful low back, vaginal discharge
- Spermatorrhea, premature ejaculation, nocturnal emissions, urinary frequency or leakage
- Liver–Kidney deficiency with blurred vision, dizziness, tinnitus, spots before eyes
- Diarrhea/loose stools, lack of appetite
- Threatened miscarriage from Kidney deficiency (restless fetus, spotting, low back soreness)

Dosage

- **10–15 g** (decoction)
- Can also be used as powder in similar daily range

Cautions / Contraindications

- Contraindicated in excess heat or damp-heat in the lower jiao (e.g., yellow discharge, burning urination)
- Use cautiously with constipation or significant yin deficiency heat if the presentation is clearly hot (scanty dark urine, constipation, dryness)
- As with many tonics: avoid if exterior pathogens are unresolved

Special Notes:

Tù Sī Zǐ is the “fertility + leakage + eyes” seed—a Kidney tonic that stabilizes Essence and calms the fetus without being as hot/drying as many Yang tonics.

Bridges Yin & Yang. Infertility without heat. *Tu Si Zi* = **balanced yin + yang** Kidney tonic

Exam-rule (Yang Tonics)

Ask:

“Is this **pure Yang deficiency**, **Yang + damp**, **Yang + leakage**, or **Yang + constipation**?”